UAV Strategy Engine: Genetic Algorithm for Disaster Surveillance

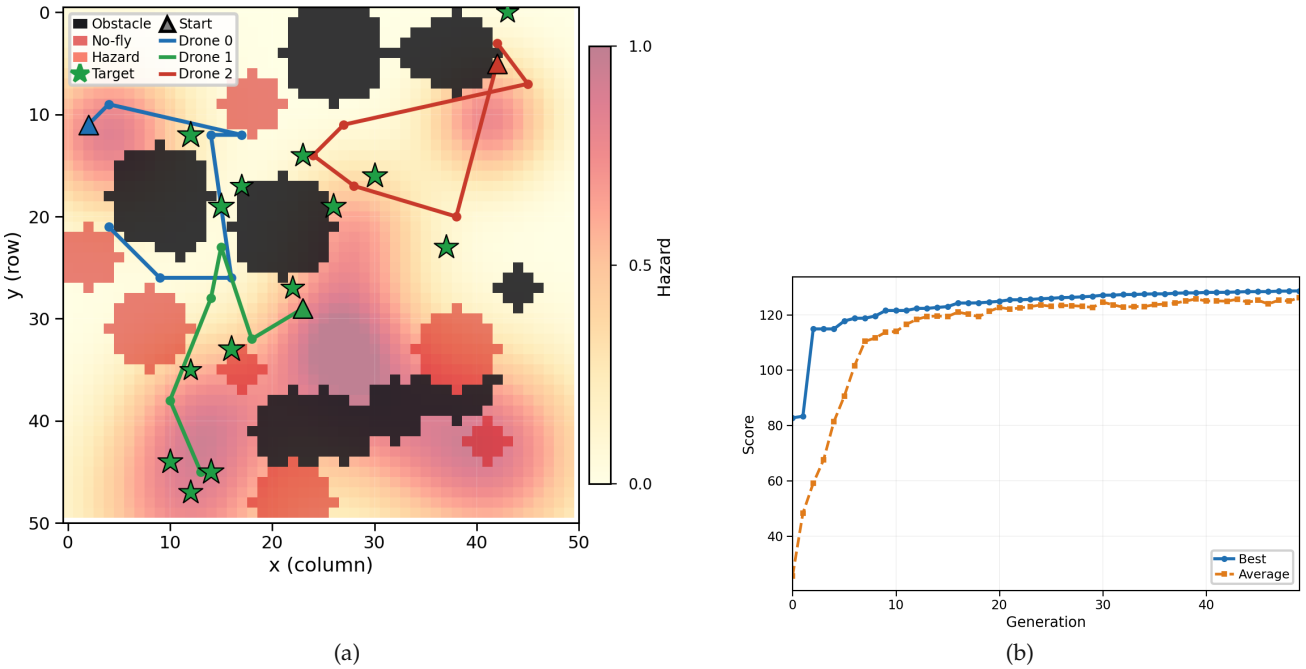
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Abstract

This assignment asks for a strategy engine that plans routes for three drones over a 50 × 50 disaster grid. Each drone must visit waypoints, choose a speed and a sensor power, and avoid obstacles, no-fly zones and dangerous cells. We use a genetic algorithm (GA) because it can search many possible routes and handle several goals at the same time. A chromosome stores every waypoint, speed and sensor choice. A simulator flies the route and gives it a score based on area coverage, target detection, energy, time and risk. We compare the GA with random search using the same number of trials. Over three seeds, the GA scored 119.1 ± 6.9 on average, while random search scored 89.6 ± 15.9. The best GA run covered all priority cells and found all 14 targets. This report explains the design, tests the main parameters, and discusses why the final route is one of many good answers rather than a single correct one.

Code and results: github.com/ChTayyabMehmood/uav-strategy-engine



(a) (b)

Figure 1 | (a) The best route found by the GA. Triangles mark the three drone bases, stars mark targets, dark cells are obstacles, and shaded cells show hazard. This run covered 100% of the priority area and found all 14 targets. (b) Best and average score over 50 generations. The average rises as the population finds more valid routes, while the best score improves quickly and then levels off.

1. Introduction

After a disaster, a small drone team must inspect the affected area quickly. Some cells are blocked, some are unsafe, and some targets are more important than others. The team also has limited battery and flight time. A good plan must balance all of these goals, so there is no single correct route.

This report presents a simple and reproducible strategy engine. Section 2 explains how a route is stored and scored. Section 3 gives the experiment setup. Section 4 compares the GA with random search, and Section 5 tests the population size, mutation rate and selection pressure. Section 6 discusses the result and its limits.

2. System Design

2.1 Chromosome representation

One chromosome describes the whole fleet. It has three blocks, one per drone. Each block stores six waypoints. A waypoint is a pair of whole-number grid coordinates (x, y), a speed level (0 = slow, 1 = normal, 2 = fast) and a sensor level (0 = off, 1 = medium, 2 = strong). The drone starts at its base and visits the waypoints in order. The speed and sensor values of a waypoint apply to the leg that leads to it.

We chose this hybrid design for two reasons. First, grid coordinates are easy to check and repair. Second, speed and sensor choices are naturally discrete. Keeping one block per drone also makes crossover simple, because a child can take a complete route from each parent without mixing two drones together.

2.2 Fitness function

The score rewards coverage (C) and target detection (D), and punishes energy (E), time (T) and risk (R). Each term is scaled between 0 and 1, so the weights show their relative importance:

$$\text{score} = 100C + 50D - 20E - 15T - 30R - P$$

C is the share of priority weight that the drones observe, and D is the share of the 14 targets they detect. E is total energy divided by the fleet limit (780), T is the longest drone flight time divided by the time limit (120), and R is the average hazard level on the cells that were flown over. P is a penalty for a route that breaks a hard constraint.

Coverage has the largest reward (+100) because inspecting the disaster area is the main task. Detection is next (+50) because finding targets is the main information the team needs. Risk has the largest punishment (−30) because flying through fire or radiation is dangerous. Energy (−20) and time (−15) have smaller weights because the hard limits already reject routes that run out of battery or take too long; these weights only prefer safer margins among valid routes.

2.3 Genetic operators and constraints

Selection uses a tournament of three routes: pick three at random and keep the best. Crossover takes two parents and swaps the last part of one drone's block, which keeps the route structure valid. Mutation visits each waypoint with probability 0.05 and then moves the waypoint, changes its speed, or changes its sensor. The two best valid routes are copied to the next generation unchanged.

A repair step runs before scoring. It pulls waypoints back inside the grid, moves them out of obstacles and no-fly cells, and repairs a leg that crosses a blocked cell. If repair cannot fix the route, the penalty P is added. The penalty is 1000 plus 50 for each violation and 25 for each unit of violation, so an invalid route cannot beat a valid one. The GA stops after 50 generations.

3. Experiment Setup

The simulation uses a 50 × 50 grid, 3 drones, 6 waypoints per drone and 14 targets. The GA uses 50 routes per generation for 50 generations, which gives 3,000 evaluations with caching. Random search also receives 3,000 evaluations. Both methods use the same simulator and score function. We repeat each method for seeds 42, 43 and 44 to reduce the effect of luck.

Table 1 | GA and random search with the same budget. Values are means over three seeds (42, 43 and 44). Higher score, coverage and targets are better; lower energy, time and risk are better.

Method	Score	Coverage	Targets	Energy	Time	Risk
Genetic algorithm	119.1 ± 6.9	92.8%	13.0 / 14	253.2	62.3	0.189
Random search	89.6 ± 15.9	77.2%	11.0 / 14	356.3	77.8	0.289

Score is the fitness from Equation 1. Coverage is the share of priority weight observed. Targets is the average number found out of 14. Risk is the average hazard level (0–1).

4. Results and Comparison

Table 1 shows that the GA is better on every measure. Its average score is 119.1, which is about 33% higher than the random-search score of 89.6. It covers 15.6 more percentage points of the priority area and finds two more targets on average. It also uses about 29% less energy and 20% less flight time, and its risk is lower (0.189 versus 0.289).

The GA is also more reliable. Its score changes by 6.9 points between seeds, while random search changes by 15.9 points. Random search depends heavily on luck: its best run scored 105.6, which is still below the GA average, and its worst run scored only 73.9. The best GA run reached 128.6, covered 100% of the priority area and found all 14 targets. That run used a larger population and 5,000 evaluations, so it is reported as the best result rather than as part of the equal-budget table.

5. Hyperparameter Sensitivity

We tested one parameter at a time with two seeds and 30 generations. The results are shown in Figure 2. A population of 50 scored 123.2, a population of 100 scored 127.0, and a population of 200 scored 127.9. The two larger populations covered 100% of the priority area, but 200 needed about twice the run time of 100, so 100 is the best balance.

For mutation, 0.01 scored 123.9, 0.05 scored 125.3 and 0.1 scored 120.7. A rate of 0.05 works best: very small changes explore too slowly, while large changes break good routes. For tournament size, 2 scored 122.1, 3 scored 125.3 and 5 scored 124.7. Size 3 gives enough selection pressure without losing diversity too quickly.

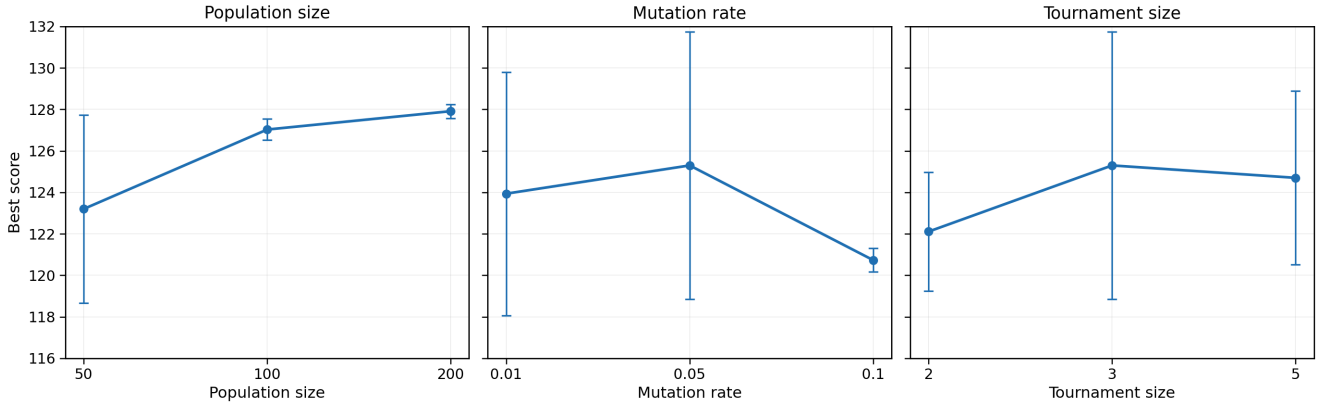


Figure 2 | Effect of population size, mutation rate and tournament size on the best feasible score. Each point is the mean of two seeds, and the bars show one standard deviation. Population size has the clearest effect; mutation 0.05 and tournament size 3 give the best mean score.

6. Discussion

The final route is not unique. Different seeds produced different routes with scores between 111.2 and 123.9, and all of them were valid. This is expected: many routes can visit the same targets in a different order. The GA therefore gives the team a set of good options, not one fixed answer. A human planner could choose a route that also avoids a school or a hospital, even if another route has a slightly higher score.

Random search is simpler, but most random routes are poor. The GA reuses good parts of routes through selection and crossover, so it improves faster with the same number of trials. In this experiment, the GA won on score, coverage, detection, energy, time and risk.

The main limitation is that the map is simulated. The drones do not face wind, moving hazards or loss of communication, and the score weights are a design choice. A real system should test more seeds, use live map data and let a human check the final plan.

7. Conclusion

This project built a complete GA strategy engine for a three-drone disaster mission. The chromosome stores waypoints, speed and sensor choices; the score balances coverage, detection, energy, time and risk; and repair keeps routes valid. The GA beat random search with the same budget, and the best run covered every priority cell and found every target. The result is one of several good routes, which is the right outcome for a problem with competing goals.

References

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